

Richmond Park - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

First Morning in a Two Thousand Year Old City

Good morning, and welcome to London. If this is your first real day in the city, take a moment on the edge of this park to get your bearings, not just north and south, but in time. London is old. The Romans founded it as Londinium around the year fifty, a trading post on the north bank of the Thames, and people have lived and argued and built here more or less continuously ever since. Two thousand years. That is the number to hold in your head today.

Here is the strange part. This old city sits on a smallish, damp island off the edge of Europe, and yet the language you are listening to right now, the shape of a courtroom, the idea of a parliament, the map of half the modern world, all of these were bent into their present form here, or carried out from here, over the last few centuries. A small island punched astonishingly far above its weight, for better and for worse, and London was the fist.

So why begin in a field full of deer? Because London will surprise you. It is one of the greenest big cities on earth, stitched through with royal parks, and this one, Richmond Park, is the largest of them all. It exists because a king wanted somewhere to hunt. That is the thread we will follow all the way through this trip, from London north to Edinburgh and York, the long, tangled story of kings and queens and the land and buildings they shaped. It starts here, under these old oaks, with the deer watching you right back.

How a Wet Little Island Grew a World

Let us zoom out for a moment, because the scale of what happened on this island is genuinely odd. When the Romans arrived, Britain was the far, cold edge of their world, the last stop before the grey ocean. Around the year fifty they laid out a town on the Thames and called it Londinium, threw a wooden bridge across the river roughly where London Bridge still stands, and turned it into a busy port. It did not go smoothly. About ten years later a warrior queen named Boudica, furious at Roman cruelty to her people, burned the whole place to the ground. The Romans rebuilt it, bigger, and Londinium became the largest city in Roman Britain, right up until the empire finally loosened its grip and the legions sailed away around the year four hundred and ten.

Then came centuries of Saxons and Vikings and Normans, invasions and marriages and mixings, and out of all that churn came a language, English, cobbled together from German and Norse and French with a heavy seasoning of Latin. Which is a large part of why it is such a magnificent, illogical mess to spell.

Here is the astonishing bit. This one rainy island, no bigger than a medium American state, went on to shape the modern world out of all proportion to its size. The language you are speaking is now the closest thing the planet has to a common tongue. The idea that even a king must answer to a law he did not personally invent, and to an assembly of representatives called a parliament, was fought over and hammered out here across long, bloody centuries. And from the sixteen hundreds onward Britain built the largest empire in history, ruling, at its height, something like a quarter of all the people on earth. That

story has a dark side we will not skip past, the conquest, the taking, the profit wrung from other people's lives. But it explains why, standing in a quiet deer park outside London, you are standing very near one of the hinges of the modern age. Not bad for a soggy island the Romans thought of as the end of the world.

Kings, Queens, and the Shape of the Ground

Here is a thing that often surprises visitors from newer countries: in Britain, the monarchy is not just ceremony and gossip and people in splendid hats. For most of the last thousand years, kings and queens were the government, and their appetites, for war, for money, for God, and yes, for hunting, physically reshaped the country. You are standing in the proof. This park exists because in sixteen thirty seven King Charles the First wanted deer to chase near London, so he threw a wall around nearly a thousand hectares of other people's farmland and declared it his. The land still holds the shape of one man's hobby, almost four hundred years later.

That is the thread we will pull all the way through this trip. Notice how often the answer to why is this here turns out to be a king or a queen. The great fortress you will visit in the city, the Tower of London, was begun by a French speaking conqueror to overawe a town he had just seized. The sprawling palace out at Hampton Court was a cardinal's dream house until Henry the Eighth simply took it, the way powerful people took things. And when we travel north into Scotland, to Edinburgh and to Stirling, we walk into a whole separate royal saga, a rival kingdom of Scottish kings and queens who spent centuries fighting, marrying, and finally merging with the English crown.

So think of the monarchy as the spine of nearly everything you are about to see. Not because kings and queens were admirable, plenty of them were monstrous, and their power was often stolen and cruel, but because for a thousand years they held the money and the armies, and money and armies are what build walls and castles and cathedrals and, as it turns out, deer parks. Keep score as we go. By the time we reach the last castle on this trip, you will have met a good stretch of the family, and you will never look at a wall in England quite the same way again.

What to Notice Before We Set Off

Before we walk, let me tell you what to notice, because it is easy to treat a park as just a green blur between the interesting bits. First, the sheer improbability of where you are. You are only about eight or nine miles from the center of one of the world's great cities, close enough that on a clear day you can actually see it, and yet it feels like open countryside, all rough grass and bracken and huge, low, ancient oak trees. Some of those oaks are older than the park itself, older than the United States, standing here quietly while whole empires came and went.

Second, notice the greenness, and understand where it came from. London is one of the greenest major cities on the planet, and that is not a happy accident of clever town planning. It is largely an accident of monarchy. Kings and queens seized great sweeps of land for hunting and for pleasure, and centuries later, when the city swelled up all around them, those royal grounds became the public parks that let London breathe. The crown's old playgrounds are now everyone's back garden. You will feel that same pattern again and again in this city.

Third, use your senses. Listen for skylarks somewhere overhead, tiny birds that pour out song while hovering in place, and for the wind moving through the bracken. Look at the way the land rolls in long open lawns, kept that way by centuries of grazing. And yes, keep half an eye out for the deer, always at a respectful distance, because they are the living reason all of this survived at all.

And here is one thing to look forward to. A little later we will climb a small rise where, if the day is clear, you can peer ten miles clear across the whole of London and catch a famous domed cathedral floating

above the treetops, a place you will stand right beneath tomorrow. For now, though, just breathe in. This is your gentle, green front door into two thousand years of history. Let us begin.

Richmond Park: A Medieval Landscape in the City

Richmond Park is the largest of London's royal parks — almost a thousand hectares, nearly three times the size of Central Park — and it's essentially a preserved medieval landscape. Charles the First brought his court to Richmond in 1625 to escape plague in London, and in 1637 he enclosed the land as a deer park, building an eight-mile wall that caused enormous local resentment. A compromise survives to this day: the public retained rights of way, and pedestrian gates still punctuate that seventeenth-century wall. The herd of around six hundred red and fallow deer isn't decorative — centuries of grazing created the park's distinctive open "lawns" dotted with ancient oaks, some of which predate the enclosure itself. The park is a Site of Special Scientific Interest and a National Nature Reserve, largely because of those veteran trees and the rare beetles that live in their decaying wood. Look for the anthills of the yellow meadow ant scattered across the grassland — some colonies are over a century old, and they're a marker of soil that has never been ploughed. You're walking through land that has looked essentially like this since the Stuarts.

The Fawning Season

You've arrived at the quietest, most secretive moment in the deer's year. Forget the autumn rut, all roaring and clashing antlers. What's happening around you right now, in early summer, is the opposite. It's birthing season, and it's designed to be invisible. From May into July the hinds and does give birth, more than two hundred calves and fawns across the park in a typical year, and almost none of them are on show. That's the whole point.

A newborn deer can't keep up with the herd. For its first week or two it can barely stand, let alone run, so it can't flee from danger. Evolution's answer is a strategy called hiding, and it's beautifully simple. The mother chooses a patch of dense cover, long grass or a stand of bracken, and settles her newborn deep inside it. The fawn lies flat, absolutely motionless, and stays there while its mother walks off to graze. She returns only a few times a day, quietly, to suckle and groom it, then leaves again. To a passerby it looks abandoned. It is nothing of the sort.

The genius is in the chemistry. Newborn fawns are born virtually scentless, and the mother licks hers clean of every trace of birth fluid, even consuming the afterbirth, so there is nothing for a fox's nose to find. A still, silent, odorless fawn tucked in the bracken is very nearly undetectable. The dappled coat, those famous white spots on a fallow fawn, does the rest, breaking up its outline in the shifting light.

This is why the park's rules change for these months. From the first of May to the end of July, dogs must be kept on leads across Richmond Park, precisely because a dog crashing off the path and into the bracken is the one predator this system can't defend against. And it's why the single worst thing a well-meaning visitor can do is pick up a fawn found lying alone. It hasn't been deserted. Handle it, or linger and drive the mother off, and you may doom it. The correct response to finding one is to note how clever you were to spot it, and then to retreat.

There's a lovely irony in all this. The rut gets the photographers and the film crews, the drama and the noise. But the survival of the herd, the thing that keeps six hundred deer walking this park four centuries after Charles the First enclosed it, hinges on this hushed midsummer moment, on mothers you'll rarely see returning to babies you'll almost never find. As you walk the bracken-fringed lawns today, keep to the paths and keep your voice down. All around you, hidden in the green, the next generation is lying perfectly still, waiting for its mother to come back.

The Beetle in the Rotten Oak

Here's a claim that sounds absurd until you understand it. The single most ecologically important thing in Richmond Park may not be the deer at all. It may be the dead wood. And the creature that makes that case is Britain's largest and most spectacular beetle, the stag beetle.

A big male is a genuinely startling animal, up to seven centimeters long, glossy chestnut and black, with a head crowned by huge branching jaws that mimic a stag's antlers so closely they gave the beetle its name. Males even duel with them in summer, grappling and trying to lever a rival off a branch, an exact miniature of the deer's own contests happening a few feet away. But there's a wonderful piece of misdirection here. Those jaws are largely ornamental, a display and a wrestling tool, so oversized that the male can barely deliver a pinch. It's the plain, smaller-jawed female who can actually nip you.

The real drama, though, is underground and invisible, and it runs for years. A stag beetle spends the overwhelming majority of its life not as a beetle but as a fat, cream-colored larva living inside decaying wood, chewing its way through rotting stumps and buried timber for anywhere from four to as many as seven years. Only at the very end does it pupate, emerge on a warm evening in June, unfold a surprising pair of wings, and lumber off through the dusk to find a mate. The adult you see droning past like a badly designed drone has perhaps a few weeks to live. Its entire beetlehood is a brief coda to years spent as a grub in the dark.

That life cycle is exactly why Richmond Park matters so much. This is a saproxylic paradise, meaning it teems with species that depend on dead and decaying wood, and the park is one of the reasons stag beetles cling on at all. Alongside Wimbledon Common and Epping Forest, this is one of the country's designated strongholds, a Special Area of Conservation for the species. The park's veteran oaks, some of them predating the enclosure of 1637, are the engine of it. When one drops a limb or finally topples, the temptation everywhere else is to tidy it away. Here, the rangers deliberately leave much of it lying, because a fallen oak isn't rubbish. It's a nursery block booked out for the next seven years.

So as you admire the great gnarled oaks today, spare a thought for the ones that are dying, and the ones already dead. In an ordinary park they'd be a liability to be cleared. In this one, they are arguably the crown jewels, and the beetle grinding away inside them is the reason a Site of Special Scientific Interest sits in the middle of London.

The Wild Park

It's worth pausing on a fact that's easy to take for granted. This is not a manicured city park with a nature theme. Richmond Park, all two and a half thousand acres of it, is a designated National Nature Reserve and a Site of Special Scientific Interest, a genuine fragment of wild Britain that happens to have London wrapped around it. And the deer, magnificent as they are, are only the headline act.

Listen, on a clear day, for the skylark. It's one of the most extraordinary sounds in British nature, a rapturous, tumbling song delivered from a bird climbing almost vertically into the sky until it vanishes to a speck, singing continuously the entire time, sometimes for minutes on end. Skylarks nest on the open ground, which makes them acutely vulnerable to trampling and disturbance, so the park designates protected nesting zones, notably around Lawn Field near the Pen Ponds, where visitors are asked to keep to the paths and dogs to leads. That birdsong raining down over the grassland is a sound most of England has lost. Here it survives, a few miles from Piccadilly.

The Pen Ponds themselves reward a stop. These two linked lakes, split by a causeway, were dug out in 1746 during gravel extraction and have since become the park's wildlife magnet, drawing herons, cormorants, grebes and wintering wildfowl. And tucked into the woodland is the park's horticultural jewel, the Isabella Plantation. The ground was first enclosed and planted in 1831 by Lord Sidmouth, but the garden you'd

walk today, its clearings, streams and ponds, was largely the creation of superintendent George Thomson and his head gardener Wally Miller from the 1950s onward. They cleared out invasive rhododendron and planted, among much else, a celebrated collection of evergreen Kurume azaleas, Japanese introductions that set the whole garden ablaze in late April and May. In July you've missed the fireworks, but it remains a cool, green, watery refuge on a hot afternoon.

And here's a name to lend the place some authority. Sir David Attenborough has lived beside this park for around seventy years and has called it his refuge and his inspiration, the wild place he escapes to. He made it the subject of a television film broadcast at the start of 2026, a personal love letter to the park's foxes, its peregrine falcons, and of course its deer.

So while the deer will rightly dominate your photographs, try to widen the lens. The skylark overhead, the heron at the pond, the azaleas in the woods, the beetle in the fallen oak, and the veteran trees themselves are all part of the same improbable thing, a working wilderness that has held its ground while one of the world's great cities grew up all around it.

King Henry's Mound: The Protected View

King Henry's Mound is probably a Bronze Age burial barrow, later repurposed as a Tudor viewing point. The legend — that Henry the Eighth stood here on the nineteenth of May, 1536, watching for the rocket from the Tower of London that confirmed Anne Boleyn's execution — is almost certainly apocryphal; records suggest he was in Wiltshire. But the view is real and remarkable: a ten-mile sightline to the dome of St Paul's Cathedral, framed through a deliberately maintained gap in the holly hedge. This is one of London's official "protected vistas," legally safeguarded since 1710, and it has genuine planning consequences: in 2009, the Manchester Unity Building at Liverpool Street was scaled back partly because a proposed tower would have loomed behind the dome in this exact sightline. There's a pleasing symmetry in starting the trip here: Wren's dome, which you'll see up close tomorrow, was for two and a half centuries the tallest building in London, and this keyhole view is a reminder of how completely it once dominated the city's skyline — and how much effort London still spends preserving that memory.

Related listening: The same Henry the Eighth of the mound legend took Hampton Court from Cardinal Wolsey. Coming up — "Wolsey's Palace, Henry's Prize" (Hampton Court Palace, Day 7).

The Legend and the Ledger

The name is doing a lot of work. King Henry's Mound, we're told, is where Henry the Eighth stood on the nineteenth of May, 1536, watching for a signal fired from the Tower of London to confirm that Anne Boleyn was dead and he was free to remarry. It's a marvelous, macabre image, and it's worth taking apart, because the gap between what's true and what's merely told is exactly where this hill gets interesting.

Start with what genuinely happened, because that part is solid and grim. Anne Boleyn, Henry's second wife, was condemned on charges almost no serious historian now believes, and executed within the Tower on that May morning. Henry supplied one macabre refinement that's sometimes dressed up as mercy. Rather than an English axe, notoriously clumsy and often needing several strokes, he sent to Calais for a French swordsman, so the thing would be done cleanly in a single blow. And his haste afterward is a matter of record. He was betrothed to Jane Seymour the very next day and married her within a fortnight, eleven days after Anne's head fell. Whatever else this was, it was not grief.

Now the legend itself, which is where the ledger stops cooperating. Could Henry have watched from here? The evidence points firmly the other way. What records survive of the king's movements place him nowhere near Richmond that day, most likely in Wiltshire, awaiting the news at a distance. And the practical objections are damning. This hill sits ten miles from the Tower. No beacon, rocket, or cannon of the period could reliably have carried a legible signal across ten miles of open country and the whole width of London. The story is physically implausible before it's even historically doubtful.

So where does it come from? Almost certainly from the human appetite to attach a great name to a striking place. The tale appears to have been grafted onto the mound long after the fact, and once a legend is that good it becomes self-sustaining, repeated until repetition hardens into supposed fact. It helps that the hill genuinely predates Henry by millennia, most likely a prehistoric burial mound, so it already carried an air of ancient importance waiting for a story to fill it.

None of which should spoil the pleasure of standing here. The Tudor connection to the park is real enough. Royal hunting on this ground goes back centuries, and the view Henry supposedly used is authentically old. Just enjoy the legend as a legend, a beautifully sinister piece of folklore wrapped around a hill that

was already thousands of years old when the Tudors arrived. The romance survives perfectly well without the footnote. It simply doesn't need to be true.

Pembroke Lodge and the Russells

Turn your attention from the mound to the elegant Georgian villa beside it, because King Henry's Mound in fact sits within the grounds of Pembroke Lodge, and the house has a history that quietly outshines the legend on the hill. It's a two-storey Georgian house with around eleven acres of landscaped gardens, and in 1847 Queen Victoria granted it to Lord John Russell, then her Prime Minister.

Russell is not a minor figure. He was one of the architects of the great Reform Act of 1832, twice Prime Minister, and he used Pembroke Lodge as a genuine seat of power, conducting government business here and entertaining a guest list that reads like a roll call of the age. Queen Victoria came. So did foreign royalty, and writers including Dickens, Thackeray, Tennyson and Longfellow, and the Italian revolutionary hero Garibaldi. For a stretch of the nineteenth century, some of the business of running an empire was transacted in a house in the middle of a deer park.

But the most consequential resident arrived as a small, grief-stricken boy. When Lord John's grandson Bertrand Russell was orphaned, losing both parents by the age of four, he was taken in by his grandparents and raised here at Pembroke Lodge, from 1876 until he went up to Cambridge in 1894. He spent his formative years in these gardens and on these lawns, a solitary, bookish child looking out over this same enormous view.

That child became one of the towering intellects of the twentieth century. Bertrand Russell was a founder of modern analytic philosophy, co-author of the monumental *Principia Mathematica*, a fearless public campaigner against war and for free thought, and a Nobel laureate in literature. The famous wit, the crystalline prose, the restless questioning of everything, all of it took root in a boy wandering this park, in the shadow of the mound where you're standing. Russell himself dated his earliest vivid memory to his arrival here as a four-year-old.

There's a satisfying density to this spot, when you tally it up. A prehistoric burial mound. A Tudor legend. A protected view of Wren's dome ten miles off. A Prime Minister's residence where Dickens dined and Victoria visited. And the childhood home of one of history's great philosophers. Most visitors climb the mound, glance through the keyhole at St Paul's, and leave without registering that the graceful house beside them holds nearly as much history as the view. Give it a look. The terrace and gardens are open, and the whole layered story of this hill is best appreciated with the Lodge included in the frame.

Beyond the Keyhole

Everyone comes to King Henry's Mound for the same thing, the famous keyhole through the hedge and the tiny dome of St Paul's suspended ten miles away. It's a superb piece of theater, and you should absolutely queue for the telescope. But before you move on, do what most visitors don't, and consider the view in the other direction, because it explains why this hill has drawn people for four thousand years.

Turn west, away from the hedge, and the land falls away into one of the great pastoral panoramas near London, the whole Thames valley opening out below you, wooded and green, the river threading through it. This is the highest point in the park, and that is the entire reason the mound matters. From up here you command the country in every direction, and elevation like that has always been valuable, to a chieftain marking the resting place of the dead, to a medieval falconer flying his birds, to a Tudor court hunting the deer, to a Victorian family taking the air. The St Paul's sightline is the celebrity, but this westward sweep is the older attraction, the one that presumably drew the mound's builders in the first place.

And that's worth dwelling on. This is very probably a prehistoric burial mound, most likely raised in the Bronze Age, which makes it thousands of years older than Wren's cathedral, older than the Tudors, older than the very idea of London as a great city. It was recognized as a monument of national importance and given formal protection in recent years. So you're standing on an ancient grave that was repurposed, across the centuries, as a lookout and a viewing station, and finally as the anchor point for one of the most fiercely defended sightlines in the modern planning system. Few spots on earth stack quite so many eras on top of one another.

Which brings the walk full circle, and points it forward. Look once more through the keyhole at that far-off dome, small enough to blot out with a fingertip. Tomorrow you'll stand directly beneath it, inside St Paul's, where the same dome soars more than a hundred meters over your head, for centuries the tallest structure in all of London. The reason you can still catch it from this exact hilltop is that generations of Londoners decided the view was worth protecting, and wrote that decision into law, bending the trajectory of the city's skyscrapers to keep this thin corridor of air clear.

So take your time with the small version now. Fix it in your memory, floating above the trees, ten miles distant. Then, standing under the real thing tomorrow, you'll understand precisely what all the fuss on this ancient hill was about.